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How universal is *wanting*?*

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The paper reports on a cross-linguistic survey of translational equivalents of the Standard Average European concept of wanting. It is conducted on a variety sample of 73 languages, each of which was checked for morphosyntactic and semantic properties of its regular means for expressing wanting, i.e. desideratives. Desideratives are shown to typically have other meanings in addition to 'want', an array of modal and mental-emotive senses. I suggest that the combination of these meanings with 'want' can insightfully be analyzed as a macrofunction, each language making its own decision about the set of situations in which its desideratives can be used. The often-claimed status of WANT as an alleged universal semantic prime is thus seriously called into question by the evidence from languages which always express wanting together with some other situations.

Keywords: semantics, typological sample, macrofunctionality, semantic prime; wanting, desiderative, modal semantic domain, mental-emotive semantic domain

1. Introduction

1.1 Setting the problem

How is the idea of wanting coded by the languages of the world? Can one speak of any uniformity or, at least, universal principles? For a European, wanting seems to be a cultural prime, something self-evident and in no need of explanation. Thus, *'I want / He wants'* easily translates from one European language to another.[1] The same logic underlies the Eurocentric conception of WANT as a lexical or even semantic universal, i.e. a concept finding (lexical) expression in any human language.

But is this true? To answer the question I checked possible ways to express the 'Standard Average European' situation of wanting in 73 languages making up a representative typological sample. The point of departure for this quest was the set of desiderative verbs of English, German, French, Spanish and Russian, i.e. the

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practical meta-languages of most descriptive grammars (cf. *want/would like, wollen/mögen, vouloir/désirer, querer, xotet'/xotet'sja*). Having enumerated the structures used in the sample languages to render the meaning of these verbs, I proceeded to make generalizations about how uniform such structures are and how well-profiled and salient the idea of wanting is.

1.2 Methodology

For this study a variety sample was used. The sampling method was that proposed in Rijkhoff & Bakker (1998), which is based on the idea that the genealogical tree of a language family reflects the degree of linguistic diversity within the family. Thus, the more branching nodes there are in the tree of a given family, the higher the diversity value of the family is. The higher the diversity value of the family, in turn, the more languages were included in the sample from the family.

A predefined list of families for a 100-languages sample was taken from Rijkhoff & Bakker (1998), though it was slightly modified in light of recent classification improvements (cf. Gordon 2005) and the poor documentation of some language families. For the current sample, from each family the language with the highest level of documentation was chosen (in line with standard typological practice). Missing languages, i.e. inadequately described languages from underdocumented language families, were not replaced by languages from better-documented families, in order to avoid distortion of the initial balance. Thus the final size of my sample was 73 languages, belonging to 63 language families. See Appendix 1 for the full list of languages of the sample.

The main sources of information about wanting were descriptive grammars, bilingual dictionaries, and translated, and often glossed, text collections;[2] information on 19 languages was complemented by detailed personal consultations with specialists in these languages.[3]

2. Multiple meanings of desideratives

2.1 Translating desideratives

The initial aim of the study was to check how the situation of wanting in its 'European' understanding was rendered in other languages, and whether one can speak of a specifically 'European' or any other culture-specific notion of wanting, or whether the same concept of wanting can be found in all languages of the world. The crucial point behind such a question was the deliberate avoidance of the doubtful presupposition of the universality of wanting.[4]

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For each language of the sample, therefore, I picked out those structures which were regularly translated with the English/German/French/Spanish/Russian (=EGFSR) desiderative verbs listed above. These structures were called DESIDERATIVES, regardless of whether the given structure was a verb (ex. (1)), a noun (ex. (2)), an affix (ex. (3)), a particle (ex. (4)) or a construction (ex. (5)).

(1) Hmong (Hmong-Mien): verb
kuv **xaav** (kuam) lub nub ci.
I **want** [(COMP) CL sun shine][5]
'I want the sun to shine'. ('Ich will, daß die Sonne scheint'.)[6] (Harriehausen 1990: 220)

(2) Ket (Yeniseian): noun
isqɔ́ ɛsaŋ peta-ra **qɔʾj**.
[fish.INF TRL] Petja-GEN.M.SG **desire (noun)**
'Petja wishes/wants to fish'. (Edward Vajda, p.c.)

(3) Shipibo-Konibo (Panoan): affix
…jain nokó-**kas**-i r-iki no-a.
there meet-**DESID**-SSSS EVID-COP 1PL-ABS
'…we want to reach that place' ('…ahí queremos llegar') (Valenzuela 2003: 997)

(4) Pilaga (Mataco-Guaicuru): particle
hadam'e **setake** da' Ø-ek.
DEM.F **DESID** COMP 3.SG_A-go
'She wanted to leave'. (Vidal 2001: 358)[7]

(5) Amele (Trans New Guinea, Madang-Albert): construction
uqa Naus **nu-ug-a** **do-na-Ø**.
he [Naus go-2SG-**IMP**] **3SG.O-3SG.S-PRS**
'He wants Naus to go'. (Roberts 1987:318)

With the desideratives in all the languages of the sample thus defined (making up altogether 136 items), I noticed that two-thirds of them also had additional translational equivalents different from EGFSR desideratives. For example, the Maltese desiderative verb *ried* is translated by the French verb *vouloir* 'want' in (6a) and at the same time by the French verb *devoir* 'must' in (6b).

(6) a. Maltese (Afro-Asiatic, Semitic)[8]
billi ma **ried**-x j-innegozja magħ-hom…
because NEG **want**.PST.3SG.M-NEG [3SG.M-bargain with-them]
'Because he did not want to bargain with them…' ('Puisqu'il ne voulait pas marchander avec eux…') (Vanhove 1993: 295)

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b. Maltese
ma r-**rid**-x n-innnegozja qalt-l-i omm-i.
NEG 1SG-**want**-NEG [1SG-bargain] say.PST.3SG.F-to-1SG mother-1SG
'I must not bargain, my mother has told me'. ('Je ne dois pas marchander, m'a dit ma mère'.) (Vanhove 1993: 300)

Similarly, the Martuthunira desiderative noun *wiru* is translated by the English verb *want* in (7a) and at the same time by the English noun *feelings* in (7b).

(7) a. Martuthunira ((Australian) Pama-Nyungan)
ngayu ***wiru*** *yungku-ngu-layi ngurnu-tharra-a*
1SG.NOM **wanting** [give-PASS-FUT that.OBL-DU-ACC
wirra-tharra-a.
boomerang-DU-ACC]
'I want to be given those two boomerangs'. (Dench 1995: 256)

b. Martuthunira
ngayu kayurtu-u nhawu-lha-nguru-rru ***wiru****-rru*
1SG.NOM smoke-ACC see-PST-ABL-NOW **feelings**-NOW
panyu-npa-layi.
good-INCH-FUT
'Having seen the smoke I'll get happy (lit. my feelings will become good)'. (Dench 1995: 276)

In the following Sections 3–4, all translational equivalents that were attested for desideratives in the descriptions of the sample languages will be presented. For the moment, I will provisionally call these translational equivalents the MEANINGS of desideratives, understanding the term primarily just as a label, with little attention to fine semantic details.[9] The problem of whether, for example, 'want' and 'must' in (6) or 'want' and 'feel' in (7) actually represent two separate meanings or just one meaning, and whether *meaning* is really the right term for such an entity, will be postponed till the final discussion in Section 7.

2.2 Factors conditioning the distribution of multiple meanings

When the same language expression can have two (or more) meanings, the question of the distribution of these multiple meanings arises. There are three logical possibilities:

a. there exists some morphosyntactic/semantic factor which conditions the distribution, and
   a1. each value of this factor allows only one of the two meanings (i.e. 'fully conditioned distribution of meanings');

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or

a2. some values of this factor allow both meanings, whereas some allow only one of them (i.e. 'partially conditioned distribution of meanings');

b. there is no morphosyntactic/semantic factor at all conditioning the distribution, i.e. only the general pragmatic or discourse context may cause a meaning preference; taken out of context, both meanings are always possible.

In actual practice, of course, there always is the fourth possibility of no information available about the distribution of the meanings. Moreover, in a situation of lack of direct access to speakers of most of the sample languages, there often is hardly any evidence for possibility (b), which is then indistinguishable from the fourth possibility.

Possibility (a1) is realized, for example, in the Southeastern Tepehuan desiderative verb *-ʾa'*: its only possible meaning is 'want' when it is used with the attributive prefix *jix-*, as in (8a), and only 'be necessary' when used with the reflexive prefix *jum-*, as in (8b).

(8) a. Southeastern Tepehuan (Uto-Aztecan)
jiñ-ʾoidya-'-ap no'-p jix-**'a'** na-p
1SG-accompany-FUT-2SG COND-2SG ATR-**want** [SUB-2SG
tu-quio-ca-' gammɨjɨ…
EXT-live-NPS-FUT always]
'Come with me if you <u>want</u> to always live (with me)…' (Willett 1991: 246)

b. Southeastern Tepehuan
jix-quɨ' gu chamarra jum-**'a'** na-ñ tɨ'-ca-'
ATR-good ART jacket REFL-**want** [SUB-1SG wear-NPS-FUT]
no'-x jɨpiʾñ.
if-ATR cold
'It <u>is necessary</u> to wear a good jacket when it's cold'. (Willett 1991: 68)

Possibility (a2) is realized, for example, in the Kham desiderative suffix *-rih-* which has both the 'want' (9a) and the 'near future/prospective' (9b–c) meanings, and the Chuvash desiderative suffix *-sšăn/-sšĕn* which has both the 'want' (10a–b) and the 'intention' meanings (10b).

(9) a. Kham (Sino-Tibetan, Tibeto-Burman)
yahm ta-ruhp-yo, ge-bahl-si-**rih**-zya.
door PROH-close-IMP 1PL-watch-MM-**DESID**-CONT
'Don't close the door, we <u>want</u> to watch'. (Watters 2002: 108)

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b. Kham
bəllə ci nə-dəi-**rih**-ke.
finally CEP 2SG-get-**DESID**-PFV
'Finally you are about to get it'. (Watters 2002: 271)

c. Kham
pəte rihm-kə bənəi zyũ:h-**rih**-zya.
later evening-LOC very cold-**DESID**-CONT
'This evening, it will be very cold'. (Watters 2002: 271)

(10) a. Chuvash (Altaic, Turkic)
ku xĕr ača xĕrele-**sšĕn**.
this woman child get_red-**DESID**
'This girl wants/(*is going) to turn red in the face {to seem embarrassed}'.
('Ėta devuška xočet/(*sobiraetsja) pokrasnet' {čtoby pokazat'sja skromnoj}') (field notes)

b. Chuvash
văl klup-a vaska-**sšăn**.
(s)he club-DA hurry-**DESID**
'He wants/is going to hurry over to the club'. ('On xočet/sobiraetsja pospešit' v klub') (field notes)

For the Kham suffix, the grammatical description Watters (2002: 270–271) presents the choice between the 'want' meaning and the 'be going to' meaning this way:

> … only in very specific contexts, especially those with 1st person entailment in the declarative, or 2nd person entailment in the interrogative, does *-rih-* still have something of a desiderative sense… By far the most common reading of the *-rih-* construction is that of imminence, and can be translated as 'to be going to', 'to be about to', etc.

Thus, in (9a) the subject of the clause is 1st person plural, and so the whole clause describes a situation of wanting. In (9b–c) the subjects are 2nd and 3rd persons, both clauses are declarative, and so both clauses describe a situation of near future. However, the person/mode parameter does not fully govern the choice, as even with a 1st person subject the 'near future' meaning is also possible, as in (11).

(11) Kham (Sino-Tibetan, Tibeto-Burman)
'ŋa: məni ŋa-ba-**rih**-zya' həi do-ke-o.
I too 1SG-go-**DESID**-IMPFV thus say-PFV-3SG
'"I am going too", she said'. (Watters 2002: 299)

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A similar situation obtains in the case of the Chuvash affix *-sšăn/-sšĕn*. It has both the 'want' and the 'intention' meanings when used with controlled predicates (as with *vaska* 'hurry' in (10b)), but only the 'want' meaning when used with uncontrolled predicates (as with *xĕrele* 'get red' in (10a)). To sum up, in 1st person clauses with the Kham affix *-rih-* and in clauses with controlled predicates marked by the Chuvash affix *-sšăn/-sšĕn*, the desiderative can have either meaning; nothing except general pragmatic context can indicate to the hearer which of the two meanings the speaker meant to express.

Possibility (b) has already been noted to be practically indistinguishable from the absence of information. For example, although the Maybrat desiderative verb *-awe* can have the 'intention' meaning, I have no information about any factors governing the distribution between the 'want' and the 'intention' meanings. The grammatical description Dol (1999: 228) says only that "*-awe* also allows a number of different interpretations, such as desire, belief/assumption and intention". Nor do the examples give any idea of the morphosyntactic or semantic differences between clauses expressing the situation of wanting, as in (12a), and those expressing the situation of intention, as in (12b).

(12) a. Maybrat (West Papuan)
pak guru y-**awe** y-o pron.
mister teacher 3M-**want** [3M-take bamboo]
'The teacher wants to take the bamboo'. (Dol 1999: 229)

b. Maybrat
m-**awe** m-no p-ana po-kuo r-ana.
3U-**want** [3U-do EMPH-3PL NOM-feast.PL POSS-3PL]
'They intend to make their feast themselves'. (Dol 1999: 229)

A detailed discussion of the *nature* of the conditioning factors for each of the meanings that were found to exist for desideratives of the sample languages goes far beyond the scope of this paper, which limits itself to an introduction to the topic of desideratives and their meanings.[10] The nature of the factors will be mentioned only briefly in passing. However, the *existence* or *absence* of such factors for each of the meanings is worth mentioning, and will be noted in the discussion below.

2.3 Further subdivision of additional meanings of desideratives

Of the 136 desideratives found in the languages of the sample, 95 happened to have other meanings besides 'want'. The aggregate of these other meanings turned out to be not just a messy, heterogeneous mixture, but to represent two clearly distinct groups: a so-called 'modal group' and a so-called 'mental-emotive group'. An

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example of the first group was given in (6) and (8)–(12), an example of the second in (7). Moreover, the two groups were strikingly close to each other quantitatively: 59 desideratives were attested as having modal meanings, while 55 desideratives were attested as having mental-emotive meanings.[11]

The next two sections (Section 3 and Section 4) will provide a closer look at each of the groups, drawing special attention to the individual meanings making them up. In both cases it will be useful to divide the meanings into three subgroups, depending on how frequently the given meaning was attested in the sample languages: COMMON meanings, INTERMEDIATE-FREQUENCY meanings, and OCCASIONAL meanings.

3. Modal meanings

3.1 Common modal meanings

The most common modal meanings of desideratives turned out to be:

- 'NEAR FUTURE/PROSPECTIVE'[12] (attested for 24 desideratives of the sample languages)
- 'NECESSITY' (17)
- 'INTENTION' (15)

The individual desideratives that were counted as having any of these three meanings are listed in Appendixes 2–4. Here I will only point to some illustrative examples.

The desiderative affix *-rih-* in Kham was already illustrated above as having the 'near future' meaning: in (9a) it was translated as 'want', but in (9b–c) as 'be about to' and 'will'.

The Semelai particle *lən* is an example of a desiderative having the 'necessity' meaning: it is translated as 'want' in (13a) and as 'necessary' in (13b).

(13) a. Semelai (Austro-Asiatic, Mon-Khmer)
daʔ kʋ=**lən**=cəʔ ca sayor knkɔn?
NEG 2FAM.A=**want**=EMPH [eat vegetable children]
'Don't you <u>want</u> to eat the children's vegetable dish?' (Kruspe 2004: 166)

b. Semelai
daʔ pakayan, **lən** ʔyot leŋ ke.
EXIST clothes **want** [return TO:up that]
'He had the clothes (<u>necessary</u>) to return up there.' (Kruspe 2004: 167)

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Table 1. Number of desideratives with modal meanings 'near future/prospective', 'necessity', 'intention'

Meaning	Number of desideratives having the meaning	Number of desideratives with fully conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	Number of desideratives with partially conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	No information
'near future/ prospective'	24	9[a]	6[b]	9
'necessity'	17	2[c]	5[d]	10
'intention'	15	1[e]	8[f]	6

[a] The following desideratives are meant: the Awa Pit affix *-shi(ta)-*, the Barasano affix *-rʉ(a)-*, the Labrador Inuttut affix *-guma-*, the Tepehua affix *-putun-*, the Southeastern Tepehuan affix *-m*, the Itelemen affix *-ał-/-a-,* the Colloquial Persian verb *xāstan*, the Kham verb *pəī*, the Shona verb *-ɗa/-dá:*.

[b] The following desideratives are meant: the Kham affix *-rih-*, the Yagua affix *-rúʉ́y*, the Hup verb *-tú(k)-*, the Rama verb *bating*, the Tukang Besi verb *hada*, the Wari' construction.

[c] The following desideratives are meant: the Kolyma Yukaghir verb *erd'e:* and the Southeastern Tepehuan verb *-'a'*.

[d] The following desideratives are meant: the Berbice Dutch Creole verb *suk(u)*, the Southern Sierra Miwok verb *hejaHw-ŋhe*, the Colloquial Persian verb *xāstan*, the Itzaj Maya verb *k'a't(ij)* and the Koasati verb *bànnan*.

[e] The following desiderative is meant: the Barasano affix *-rʉ(a)-*.

[f] The following desideratives are meant: the Chuvash affix *-sšăn/-sšĕn*, the Babungo verb *kɔ́ɔ*, the Maricopa verb *'i(i)-*, the Rama verb *bating*, the Tukang Besi verb *hada*, the Chuvash verbs *šutla/šuxăšla* and *te*, the Russian verb *xotet'*.

The Chuvash desiderative affix *-sšăn/-sšĕn*, which has either only the 'want' meaning, as in (10a)), or both the 'want' and the 'intention' meanings, as in (10b), was already mentioned above.

In Table 1 the respective numbers of desideratives with each type of distribution of meanings 'near future/prospective', 'necessity', 'intention' are indicated.

The general impression from Table 1 is that, for these main modal meanings, in roughly every second case there are some morphosyntactic or semantic factors at least partially conditioning the distribution between the two meanings available (i.e. the 'want' meaning vs. the particular non-desiderative meaning). An *unambiguous choice* between the two meanings, however, can be guaranteed only rarely (just 12 desideratives out of a total of 56 desideratives, i.e. 21%).

The fact that conditioning factors exist exactly to this extent, i.e. not more often and not less often, is important and its consequences will be discussed in Section 7.

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3.2 Intermediate-frequency modal meanings

In the previous section I discussed those modal meanings which frequently co-occur with the 'want' meaning. Other modal meanings also occur, but with lower frequency. These intermediate-frequency modal meanings turned out to be:

- 'OBLIGATION' (attested for 9 desideratives of the sample languages)
- 'PURPOSE' (7)
- 'ILLOCUTION/CAUSATION' (6)
- 'ABILITY' (5)

Again, the individual desideratives having these meanings are listed in Appendixes 5–8; here only a couple of examples are provided.

The 'obligation' meaning has already been exemplified by sentences (6a–b) above with the Maltese desiderative verb *ried*, translated both as 'want' and as 'must'.

By the 'illocution/causation' meaning I understand here the union of the following quite close meanings: 'imperative', 'optative', 'permission', and 'ask'. Each of these was attested only once or twice, and therefore would not individually count as a intermediate-frequency modal meaning if taken separately. At the same time, all of them clearly have to do with the general concept of illocution/causation — an illocutionary force tending to bring about (or at least to further) the realization of an event — whose connection to wanting seems intuitively important and worth exploring.[13]

The 'purpose' meaning is exhibited by the Maori noun *tuumanako* in (14) and the Korowai special (so-called "intentional/adhortative/imperative") set of cross-reference suffixes in (15).

(14) a. Maori (Austronesian, Oceanic)
ko te **tuumanako**, kia tae mai koutou ki taa
EQ DEF **wish** [SUBJ arrive hither 2PL to SG.GEN
taatou hui.
1PL_INCL meeting]
'It is (our) wish that you should come to our meeting'. (Bauer 1993: 42)

b. Maori
ko taku **tùmanako** kia oti tènei mahi
EQ SG.GEN.1SG **wish** [SUBJ complete this action
i te ono marama.
PREP DEF six month]
'My aim is to complete this work in six months'. (Ngata 2005)[14]

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(15) a. Korowai (Trans-New Guinea, Main Section)
le-**fén**. / le-**tin**.
eat-1PL.**DESID&OPT** / eat-3PL.**DESID&OPT**
'We <u>want</u> to eat, let us eat'. / 'They <u>want</u> to eat, let them eat'. (van Enk & de Vries 1997: 95)

b. Korowai
le-mén-dakhu nokhu lép-telo-khai-kha noku
eat-2PL.DESID&OPT-SS we ill-be-3SG.IRR-CONN us
mano-pa-mon-do khi-telo-**fon**-è.
good-SUPP-2PL.DESID&OPT-DS [healthy-be-1PL.**DESID&OPT**-CONN]
'You should eat it and if we fall ill, you should cure us <u>so we can be healthy</u>'. (van Enk & de Vries 1997: 161)

The 'imperative' meaning is attested in the Hua desiderative affix *-su-/-si-/-sa-*, which can be translated either as 'want' (cf. (16a)) or as 'imperative' (cf. (16b)).

(16) a. Hua (Trans-New Guinea, Main Section)
de-**sa**-pe?
eat-**DESID**.2SG/NON_1.NON_SG-INTER
'Do you (sg/pl) <u>want</u> to eat?' (Haiman 1980: 441)

b. Hua
de-**si**-e!
eat-**DESID**.3SG-NON_2.SG/NON_1.PL
'<u>Let</u> him eat!' (Haiman 1980: 442)

The 'ask' meaning is illustrated by the Southeastern Tepehuan desiderative verb *-'a'*, cf. (8a) and (17).

(17) Southeastern Tepehuan (Uto-Aztecan)
…agre'n ba-**'a'** gu viñ na-ch ga'hl-idya-'.
irrational TWD-**want** [ART wine] [SUB-1PL sell-APPL-FUT]
'(A drunk came here last night to bother us.) He was senselessly <u>asking</u> us to sell him wine'. (lit. 'He was <u>asking</u> some wine to sell'). (Willett 1991: 248)

Finally, the 'ability' meaning can be seen in (18), where the Kamaiura affix *-potar-* is translated simultaneously as 'want' and as 'can'.

(18) Kamaiura (Tupi, Tupi-Guarani)
n=a-'ata-**potar**-ite.
NEG=1SG-go-**DESID**-NEG
'I <u>don't want</u> to go'. / 'I <u>can't</u> go'. ('Não <u>quero</u>/<u>posso</u> andar') (Seki 2000: 132)

As for the existence or absence of factors governing the distribution of 'want' vs. the respective 'other' meaning — 'obligation', 'illocution/causation', 'purpose', or

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Table 2. Number of desideratives with modal meanings 'obligation', 'illocution/causation', 'purpose', 'ability'

Meaning	Number of desideratives having the meaning	Number of desideratives with fully conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	Number of desideratives with partially conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	No information
'obligation'	9	2[a]	4[b]	3
'illocution/causation'	6	1[c]	1[d]	4
'purpose'	7	0	2[e]	5
'ability'	5	1[f]	1[g]	3

[a] The following desideratives are meant: the Ingush verb *-eza* and Maricopa verb *'i(i)-*.
[b] The following desideratives are meant: the Hua affix *-su-/-si-/-sa-*, the Maltese verb *ried*, the Georgian verb *-nd-* and the Telugu construction 'Subject-DAT [V-OBLIGATIVE+COMP] is'.
[c] The following desiderative is meant: the Southeastern Tepehuan verb *-'a'*.
[d] The following desiderative is meant: the Korowai special (so called "intentional/adhortative/imperative") set of cross-reference suffixes.
[e] The following desideratives are meant: the Korowai special (so called "intentional/adhortative/ imperative") set of cross-reference suffixes and the Kayardild affix *-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru).*
[f] The following desiderative is meant: the Semelai particle *lən*.
[g] The following desiderative is meant: the Kayardild affix *-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru).*

'ability' — few tendencies can be mentioned (cf. Table 2). One can note a higher proportion of fully or partially conditioned distribution for the 'obligation' meaning in comparison to the other modal meanings, and a lower proportion of conditioned distribution for the 'illocution/causation' meaning in comparison to the other modal meanings.

3.3 Occasional modal meanings

Finally, the rarer, occasional modal meanings of desideratives that were found are:

- 'ATTEMPT' (attested for 3 desideratives of the sample languages)
- 'UNREAL' (3)
- 'READINESS' (1)
- 'REPETITION IN THE PAST' (1)[15]

The desideratives having these occasional meanings are listed in Appendix 9. Following is a random example of such a case, namely, the Yagua desiderative affix, translated as 'want' in (19a) and as 'try' in (19b).

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Table 3. Number of desideratives with occasional modal meanings

Meaning	Number of desideratives having the meaning	Number of desideratives with fully conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	Number of desideratives with partially conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	No information
'attempt'	3	0	1[a]	2
'unreal'	3	0	2[b]	1
'readiness'	1	0	1	0
'repetition in the past'	1	0	0	1

[a] The following desiderative is meant: the Maricopa verb *'i(i)-*.
[b] The following desideratives are meant: the Korowai special (so called "intentional/adhortative/ imperative") set of cross-reference suffixes and the Tukang Besi affix *-um-*.

(19) a. Yagua (Peba-Yaguan)
sṵ́ṵ́ṵnaaryṵ́ṵ́tyáññíí.
sa-júnaay-**rṵ́ṵ́y**-tániy-níí.
3SG-cry-**DESID**-CAUS-3SG
'He makes him want to cry'. (Payne 1985: 292)

b. Yagua
A: sy̰y̰íteenú?
really
'Really?'
B: Jóó. Yą-ą-tiy jarúpan-ta-**rṵ́ṵ́**-ñíí.
yes 2SG-IRR-COND bother-TR-**DESID**-3SG
'Yes. If you try to bother her'. (Payne 1992: 167)

4. Mental-emotive meanings

4.1 Common mental-emotive meanings

By far the most common mental-emotive meaning turned out to be the 'LIKE/LOVE' meaning; the number of desideratives having it was as high as 32 (see Appendix 10). Note that not all languages have a distinction similar to that between 'like' and 'love'; and even where a similar distinction exists, it is not always fully equivalent to that observed in the meta-language (English and others). Such information being lexical, however, it is hardly available in most grammatical sources, and so 'like' and 'love' are treated together in this study.

Examples (20) and (21) illustrate both 'like' and 'love', showing also that the

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'like/love' meaning can pertain either to activities ('like to cook' in (20b)) or to objects ('love children' in (21b)).

(20) a. Mupun (Afro-Asiatic, Chadic)
n-**ɗem** n-man ar də mo cin ɗì.
1SG-**want** [COMP-know way REL 3PL do OPT/ANAPH]
'I want to know how they do it'. (Frajzyngier 1993: 472)
b. Mupun
wa də **ɗem** n-cet gwom.
3SG PST **want** [COMP-cook food]
'She liked to cook'. (Frajzyngier 1993: 471)

(21) a. Chatino (Oto-Manguean)
ʔo n aʔn nty-**katiʔ** n kw-lu n.
also 1SG 1SG CONT-**want** 1SG [POT-grow 1SG]
'I also want to grow'. (Rasch 2002: 296)
b. Chatino
ma nty-**katiʔ** ʔin snyeʔ Ø lo n-ta na
mother CONT-**want** [to child 3] and HAB-give thing
nty-ku snyeʔ Ø.
HAB-eat child 3
'The mother loves and feeds her children'. (Rasch 2002: 294)

Information about possible factors conditioning the distribution of the 'like/love' vs. 'want' meanings is very scarce. Only one desiderative is known to have a fully conditioned distribution,[16] while two desideratives have a partially conditioned distribution.[17]

It is worth noting, though, that such a situation may not reflect the real state of affairs, but rather may derive from the lexical nature of the opposition, which is not very likely to be commented on in typologically oriented linguistic literature.

4.2 Intermediate-frequency mental-emotive meanings

The intermediate-frequency mental-emotive meanings turned out to be 'THINK' (attested for 11 desideratives of the sample languages) and 'SAY' (attested for 10), see Appendixes 11–12. Examples are the Hmong verb *xav*, translated as 'want' in (22a), but as 'think' in (22b), and the Mapuche verb *pi*, translated as 'want' in (23a), but as 'say' in (23b).

(22) a. Hmong (Hmong-Mien)
kuv **xav** kom nws mus.
I **want** [COMP_PURP he go]
'I want him to go'. (Bisang 1992: 287)

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b. Hmong
kuv **xav** hais tias nej yuav tsis tuaj.
I **want** [say say.COMP you FUT NEG come]
'I thought you (pl) would not come'. (Bisang 1992: 290)

(23) a. Mapuche (Araucanian)
pi-y-m-i mi küđaw-al.
want-IND-2-SG [POSS.2SG work-NMLZ]
'You wanted to work'. (Smeets 1989: 259)

b. Mapuche
"kümé presedente đulli-entu-a-y-iñ"
[good president choose-take.out-NRLD-IND-1NON_SG-PL]
pi-y engün.
want-IND.3 they
'"We will choose a good president", they said'. (Smeets 1989: 528)

Interestingly, for most of the desideratives having the double meanings in question, there are factors fully or partially conditioning the choice between the two meanings.[18] With two exceptions,[19] this concerns the selection of different complementation strategies with desiderative *verbs* (note that 19 of the overall 21 desideratives having the 'think' or 'say' meanings are in fact verbs).

On the one hand, in order to be interpreted as 'say', a verb will make use of the direct-speech complementation strategy, with the usual independent-sentence verb forms and direct-speech deixis. On the other hand, to be interpreted as 'want', the verb will use the complementation strategy which is more modally marked, rather than the unmarked complementation strategy giving the 'think'/'say' interpretation. Thus in (23b) the Mapuche verb *pi* is translated as 'say' when it takes a direct-speech complement (cf. the finite verb form and 1st person cross-reference affix), but as 'want' in (23a), where it takes a nominalized complement. And in (22a) the Hmong verb *xav* takes a modal purpose complementizer *kom* and is translated as 'want', but takes the modally neutral thought/speech complementizer *hais tias* in (22b), where it is translated as 'think'.

However, only for a few desideratives is this differentiation by complementation strategy unambiguous. In all other cases, one of the two strategies — generally either the modally less marked strategy or an indirect-speech strategy — allows both possible translations, 'think' or 'say' as well as 'want', while the other strategy allows only one of the possible translations (only 'want' if this is the more modally marked strategy, and only 'say' if it is the direct-speech strategy).[20]

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4.3 Occasional mental-emotive meanings

All the other mental-emotive meanings are much lower in frequency than the common 'like/love', 'think' and 'say' meanings; they cannot be divided into clear subgroups, as the decrease in number of attestations is truly gradual:

- 'FEEL' (attested for 5 desideratives of the sample languages)
- 'ACCEPT/AGREE' (4)
- 'HOPE' (3)
- 'KNOW' (2)
- 'DECIDE' (2)
- 'LOOK FOR' (1)
- 'SEEM' (1)

Individual desideratives having these meanings are listed in Appendix 13. An example of a desiderative having the 'feel' meaning was given above (cf. (7) from Martuthunira). Below are given examples for the 'accept' (24) and 'hope' (25) meanings.

(24) a. Ingush (North Caucasian)
wa pirog ja'a-r suona **lou.**
[you.ERG pie CL.eat-NMLZ] I.DAT **want**
'I want you to eat the pie'. ('Ja xoču, čtoby ty s"jel pirog'.) (Sultan Mereshkov, p.c.)

b. Ingush
cuo(-m) shiiga eanna-r **lou.**
he.ERG(-INTENS) [REFL.3SG.ALL say.PASS-NMLZ] **want**
'He accepts whatever (people) say to him'. ('On terpit čto by emu ni skazali'.) (Sultan Mereshkov, p.c.)

(25) a. Kham (Sino-Tibetan, Tibeto-Burman)
'su-lai zə gəhcə ta-ta-kə' **li**-də
[who-OBJ EMPH inconvenience PROH-be-OPT] **want/say**-NFIN
ŋa-ma-hu-ke.
1SG-NEG-come-PFV
'Not wanting to inconvenience anyone, I didn't come'.
(lit. 'Saying, "May no one be inconvenienced"…') (Watters 2002: 314)

b. Kham
'gəh-ba-zya-rə-kə bə' həi ge-**li**-zya-o.
[HORT-go-CONT-3PL-OPT also] thus 1PL-**want/say**-CONT-NMLZ
'"May they just go away" we were hoping'. (Watters 2002: 342)

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Table 4. Number of desideratives with occasional mental-emotive meanings

Meaning	Number of desideratives having the meaning	Number of desideratives with fully conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	Number of desideratives with partially conditioned distribution of this meaning vs. 'want' meaning	No information
'feel'	5	1[a]	2[b]	2
'accept/agree'	4	3[c]	0	1
'hope'	3	0	2[d]	1
'know'	2	0	0	2
'decide'	2	0	0	2
'look for'	1	0	0	1
'seem'	1	0	1	0

[a] The following desiderative is meant: the Yimas verb *ty*.
[b] The following desideratives are meant: the Telugu verb *an* and the Martuthunira verb *wirunpa*.
[c] The following desideratives are meant: the Ingush verb *lou*, the Motuna verb *haa* and the Mupun verb *ɗem/dem*.
[d] The following desideratives are meant: the Hmong verb *xav/xaav/sǎŋ* and the Kham verb *(həi) li*.

As for the existence of factors governing the choice between 'want' and one of the alternative meanings discussed here, a glance at Table 4 shows that such factors exist in about 50% of the cases.

Of the desideratives having occasional mental-emotive meanings, the more common subtypes, i.e. those with the 'feel', 'accept/agree' and 'hope' meanings, are characterized by a fairly high frequency of cases where there are factors known to condition the distribution of meanings, at least partially. For the other subtypes there is no information, but the small number of cases precludes any serious predictions.

5. Combinations of meanings

Having surveyed the inventory of individual additional meanings that were attested for the desideratives of the sample languages, we turn now to the question of their possible combinations.

As will already have been noticed from examples (8) and (17), a desiderative can have more than one meaning in addition to 'want': the Southeastern Tepehuan desiderative verb *-ʾa'* was shown to have the modal meanings 'necessity' (cf. (8)) and 'illocution/causation' (cf. (17)). This is by no means the only such case. Moreover, cases where the 'want' meaning was combined with more than two individual additional meanings were also attested. An example is the Semelai particle

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lən; this was shown to have the 'want' and 'necessity' meanings in (13), and it can also be translated as 'be able' (cf. (26a)) and 'near future' (cf. (26b)).

(26) a. Semelai (Austro-Asiatic, Mon-Khmer)
(The woman in question is under a taboo, preventing her from putting her hand in a pot. The question is, how will she eat in such circumstances?)
lən ca, hɔ̃nmande **lən** cluk kdeŋ?
want eat how **want** put.in pot
'(If) she wanted to eat, how was she able to put (her hand) in the pot?'
(Kruspe 2004: 331)

b. Semelai
ʔəɲ=**lən** ŋren kʊ!
1FAM.A=**want** be.angry 2FAM
'I'll get angry, you!' (Kruspe 2004: 434)

Combinations of meanings belonging to different semantic groups are also possible. For example, the Shipibo-Konibo desiderative affix *-kas* (cf. (3)) can be translated both as Spanish *pensar* 'intend/plan' (cf. (27a)), i.e. with a modal meaning, and as English 'like' (cf. (27b)), i.e. with a mental-emotive meaning.

(27) a. Shipibo-Konibo (Panoan)
cartucho bi-we, nato jene be-ai
bullet get-IMP this flowing_water.ABS come_in.SG-INCOMPL
jiki-**kas**-i r-iki no-a.
enter-**DESID**-SSSS DIR_EV-COP 1PL-ABS
'Get bullets, we are planning to enter (the jungle) during this rainy season.' ('Consiga cartucho, en este invierno pensamos entrar (al monte)'.) (Valenzuela 2003: 997–998)

b. Shipibo-Konibo
bewa-**kas** / xoin i-**kas**
sing-**DESID** / whistle do.INTR-**DESID**
'one who likes to sing' / 'one who likes to whistle' (Valenzuela 2003: 167)

However, desideratives having only a *single* meaning in addition to 'want' are more numerous (54%) than those with *several* additional meanings (46%). Indeed, as can be seen from Table 5, of the overall 95 desideratives having other meanings in addition to 'want' (136 – 41 = 95 in Table 5), desideratives having only a single meaning in addition to 'want' number 51 (25 desideratives having only a single modal meaning and 26 desideratives having only a single mental-emotive meaning), while there are 44 desideratives with several additional meanings (all the other desideratives having other meanings in addition to 'want', i.e. 95 – 51 = 44).

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Table 5. Number of desideratives for each combination of meanings

	0 modal meanings	**1 modal meaning**	**>1 modal meanings**	**Σ**	
0 mental-emotive meanings	41	25	15	81	
1 mental-emotive meaning	26	**10**	**6**	42	mental-emotive meanings: 42+13= **55**
>1 mental-emotive meanings	10	**3**	**0**	13	
Σ	77	38	21	**136**	
		modal meanings: 38+21=**59**			

Moreover, desideratives with several additional meanings belonging to the *same* semantic group are more numerous (26%) than those having meanings from *different* semantic groups (20%): out of the overall 95, there are 25 of the former (15 desideratives with several modal meanings in addition to 'want' and 10 with several mental-emotive meanings in addition to 'want'), versus only 19 of the latter (10 + 6 + 3 = 19 in Table 5). Finally, not a single desiderative was attested to have a combination of several modal and several mental-emotive meanings.

The figures cited in Table 5 suggest that the more complex a given combination of meanings is — either quantitatively (number of meanings) or structurally (meanings from two different groups) — the lower its chances of being attested within a desiderative. This result is particularly interesting given the fact that desideratives with other meanings in addition to 'want' are in fact more numerous than those having only the 'want' meaning.

If most desideratives in my sample tend to have one more meaning in addition to the Standard Average European 'want' meaning, then the SAE concept of wanting in relation to desideratives cross-linguistically can be characterized as relatively 'narrow' (but not 'very narrow' which could be the case if several additional meanings were attested by desideratives of the sample more often than a single additional meaning). This fact is worth noting, first of all, given the importance in 'Western' linguistic studies of using SAE concepts in formulating research questions. This discussion will be continued in Section 7.

6. Core and peripheral meanings

The above presentation of the modal and mental-emotive meanings of desideratives has proceeded from more frequent to less frequent. Table 6 shows all the frequencies together.

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Table 6. Number of each attested meaning of desideratives

Modal meanings (91)	**Mental-emotive meanings (71)**[a]
'near future/prospective' (24)	'like/love' (32)
'necessity' (17)	
'intention' (15)	
	'think' (11)
	'say' (10)
'obligation' (9)	
'purpose' (7)	
'illocution/causation' (6)	
'ability' (5)	
	'feel' (5)
	'accept/agree' (4)
'attempt' (3)	'hope' (3)
'unreal' (3)	'know' (2)
'readiness' (1)	'decide' (2)
'repetition in the past' (1)	'look for' (1)
	'seem' (1)

[a] The numbers of overall modal meanings (91) and mental-emotive meanings (71) in Table 6 differ from those in Table 5 (59 and 55, respectively), as Table 5 counted the desideratives having the given meanings, while Table 6 counts the meanings themselves. For example, a desiderative with several meanings was counted only once in Table 5 (as a desiderative with more than one meaning), but each of its meanings was counted separately in Table 6.

Both for modal and for mental-emotive meanings, there are three distinct frequency groups: the most common, the intermediate-frequency, and the occasional. It is noteworthy that the boundary between them is quite sharp in three out of four cases (cf. the drop from 15 to 9, from 32 to 11, and from 10 to 5); only in one case (the drop from 5 to 3 under 'modal meanings') is there no sharp demarcation line. That is, it is generally not a matter of a continuum of meanings whose frequency gradually decreases step by step.

It is quite generally accepted that cross-linguistic frequency is important enough to make substantial generalizations.[21] Regarding desideratives, it means that this frequency could be used for a division of additional meanings into "core meanings" and "peripheral meanings". Yet the sample that this study was based on was not a *probability* sample, but a *variety* sample. Variety samples are supposed to be useful tools for an exploratory typological research: "when little is known about the form or construction under investigation it is important that the sample offers a maximum degree of variation for the linguistic parameters involved" (Rijkhoff & Bakker 1998: 265). Unfortunately, variety samples provide rather limited information on the probability of occurrence of the linguistic phenomena which they discuss, even though probability of occurrence is the central topic of probability samples (see Rijkhoff & Bakker (1998) for more details). This means that

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the statistical correlations for desideratives observed within the languages of my variety sample are not necessarily the same as those which might be observed on the set of all human languages (which would be the case if my sample was a probability sample). Hence, the frequency alone could not be a valid criteria for making decisions about the centrality or peripherality of particular desideratives in the course of my study, just because these calculations would not hold with sufficient reliability in *any* variety sample. However, another phenomenon was attested offering additional evidence that the cross-linguistic frequency tendencies are indeed real. The phenomena, which is a bit complex, will be spelled in detail below, but in a nutshell the idea is this: in contexts where the additional meaning of a desiderative does not belong to the semantic type that is typical for its formal type, only the common and intermediate-frequency meanings turned out to be attested. This argues strongly that these meanings are in fact frequent not only in the sample languages, but presumably in all languages of the world.

The cases in question arise in a number of combinations of values of the parameter of morphosyntactic type of desiderative (verb, affix, particle, etc., cf. 2.1) and the parameter of semantic group of meaning. Thus, while desideratives of all morphosyntactic types (except constructions) show roughly the same proportion of desideratives having other meanings in addition to 'want' (cf. the 3rd column in Table 7), there is, for each morphosyntactic type, an evident preference to have

Table 7. Desideratives having other meanings in addition to 'want', by morphosyntactic type and by semantic group of meanings

Morphosyntactic type	Total number of desideratives belonging to the type	Desideratives having other meanings in addition to 'want' (percent of all desideratives of the type)	Desideratives with modal meanings (percent of all desideratives of the type)	Desideratives with mental-emotive meanings (percent of all desideratives of the type)
Verbs	79	59 (**75%**)[a]	33 (42%)	41 (**52%**)[b]
Affixes	27	20 (**74%**)	23 (**68%**)[c]	4 (12%)
Particles	7	5 (**71%**)		
Nouns	11	6 (**55%**)	1 (9%)	6 (**55%**)
Constructions	12	5 (42%)	2 (17%)	4 (33%)
Total	136	95 (**70%**)	59 (43%)	55 (40%)

[a] In Table 7, numbers which are greater than or equal to 50% are given in boldface.

[b] For each morphosyntactic type, the sum of desideratives with modal meanings and desideratives with mental-emotive meanings is higher than the overall number of desideratives having other meanings in addition to 'want', as a desiderative can have both a modal and a mental-emotive meaning at the same time (see Section 5).

[c] Affixes and particles are treated together here, as separately they yield figures that are too small to calculate meaningful percents. Such a treatment is possible due to the close morphosyntactic properties of affixes and particles (see Khanina (2005) for details).

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Table 8. Desideratives having meanings from an "untypical" semantic group

Morphosyntactic type	Meanings from the "untypical" semantic group	Number of desideratives having the meaning
Verbs	'near future'	8
	'necessity'	14
	'intention'	12
	'obligation'	4
	'illocution/causation'	3
	'ability'	1
	'attempt'	2
Affixes and particles	'love'	3
	'think'	1
Nouns	'necessity'	1
	'purpose'	1
Constructions	'near future'	1
	'obligation'	1
	'love'	2
	'think'	1
	'seem'	1

meanings belonging to one and not to the other semantic group (cf. the 4th and the 5th columns of Table 7). Desiderative verbs and desiderative nouns tend to have additional mental-emotive meanings, but not modal meanings; by contrast, desiderative affixes and desiderative particles tend to have additional modal meanings, but not mental-emotive ones. It should be noted that for verbs this tendency is not as strong as for the other morphosyntactic types of desideratives; however, it is certainly present.

The crucial question is: in those rare cases when a desiderative does have a meaning from a semantic group *not* typical for the given morphosyntactic type, what kind of meaning is it? It turned out that such meanings tended strongly to be among those that were described above as the common or, at least, the intermediate-frequency ones (see Table 8 for figures and Appendixes 14–17 for the lists of concrete desideratives).

In fact, the majority of desiderative verbs having modal meanings (34) have the most common modal meanings 'near future/prospective', 'necessity', and 'intention'; almost all the rest of them (8) have the intermediate-frequency modal meanings 'obligation', 'illocution/causation' and 'ability'; and only one desiderative verb has an occasional modal meaning 'attempt'.

Only two desiderative nouns have modal meanings; one such meaning ('necessity') belongs to the common group, while the other ('purpose') belongs to the intermediate group.

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The majority of desiderative affixes having mental-emotive meanings (3) have the common mental-emotive meaning 'like/love'; the single other case has the intermediate-frequency mental-emotive meaning 'think'.

As for desiderative constructions, no semantic group is typical for them, though they might have some slight preference for the mental-emotive meanings (cf. Table 7). When they do have another meaning, it is the high frequency modal meaning 'near future', the intermediate-frequency modal meaning 'obligation' and the common mental-emotive meanings 'like/love' and 'think'. The occasional mental-emotive meaning 'seem' might be due to the suggested preference towards the mental-emotive group.

In summary, I now have not one but two independent cross-linguistic frequency measurements which characterize, within the bounds of my sample, one group of meanings as more frequent than the other group. First, there are significantly more cases where the meanings of the first group were attested. Second, there exist special conditions (set by a combination of morphosyntactic type with semantic type) where the meanings of the first group were attested and the meanings of the second group were not attested. While frequency per se cannot be taken as generally true if observed on a variety sample (see above), the unanimity of the frequency results in two independent 'experiments' pronounces for the validity of the frequency tendencies beyond the given sample, i.e. presumably in all languages of the world.

Therefore, the additional meanings of desideratives can indeed be split into two groups, which we may call core (a) and peripheral (b):

a. 'near future/prospective', 'necessity', 'intention', 'obligation', 'illocution/ causation', 'purpose', 'ability'; 'like/love', 'think', 'say';[22]
b. 'attempt', 'unreal', 'readiness', 'repetition in the past'; 'feel', 'accept/agree', 'hope', 'know', 'decide', 'look for', 'seem'.

The notion of core status involves two points, a substantive one and an epistemological one. First, the core meanings belong to semantic domains more closely allied conceptually to 'wanting' than is the case with the other semantic domains: if it were not the case, the core meanings would not be consistently encoded by one and the same linguistic means. Second, the core meanings definitely exist — i.e. the probability of an overall descriptive mistake is low, which is not true for the peripheral meanings. Individual cases of the latter could turn out to be a misinterpretation of the data by the descriptive source, or my own misinterpretation of the descriptive source, as the cases attested are really below the confidence interval for 136 desideratives.

One more suggestion can be made regarding the difference between core and peripheral meanings. Since the latter are attested only accidentally and sporadically,

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they might not be connected *directly* to the 'want' meaning, but rather be primarily linked to other meanings. In fact, a strikingly large fraction of desideratives having peripheral meanings have more than one additional meaning (21 out of 26, i.e. 81%, see Appendix 18), the additional meaning(s) always being a core meaning(s). It may well be these core meanings which are conditioning the existence of the peripheral meanings.

However, further study is needed in order to understand the individual semantic relations between each of the additional meanings (with a special attention to the core meanings) and wanting. Such a study should, first, go beyond the plain opposition 'want' vs. other meanings and analyze the mutual semantic relationship between these other meanings per se (otherwise no semantic map, an extremely useful tool for semantic analysis (see, e.g., Haspelmath (2003)), can be built); second, it should investigate diachronic relations between all the meanings in question.

7. Discussion: Is *wanting* universal?

In the previous section I have shown that the structures used in the world's languages to render the 'European' situation of wanting tend to have more than one translational equivalent in English and other European languages. How can this situation be analyzed and what lies behind the translational equivalents?

Probably the classical answer to the question would be to invoke polysemy, thus admitting polysemy to be common for desideratives. Such a point of view is expressed in Harkins (1995),[23] a study of wanting in the framework of Anna Wierzbicka's Natural Semantic Metalanguage (NSM): cf. the author's remark "It has been observed that the commonest elements in languages are those most likely to be polysemous" (Harkins 1995: 234–235). The next analytical step would then be a search for the conditions on such a polysemy, i.e. "specifiable differences in syntactic or semantic contexts of occurrence" (Harkins: ibid.). As Harkins' study acknowledges and makes use of the polysemy analysis, it is worth looking at an example of how the conditions are stated there. Guided by her concept of "disambiguation strategies", the author comments on the polysemy of the Bahasa Indonesia desiderative *suka* in (28a–b):

(28) a. Bahasa Indonesia (Austronesian, Malayo-Polynesian)
ali **mau** kopi.
Ali **want** (coffee)
'Ali **wants** coffee'. (Harkins 1995: 57)

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b. Bahasa Indonesia
ali **suka** kopi.
Ali **want/like** (coffee)
'Ali **likes/wants** coffee'. (Harkins 1995: 58)

She says:

> …it does not mean that in Bahasa Indonesia the concepts 'want' and 'like' are somehow merged. When *suka* is used in its desiderative sense, *mau* 'want' can be substituted for it; and when *suka* refers to liking, *mau* cannot be substituted for it… (Harkins 1995: 58)

In other words, the polysemy is admitted to be conditioned if at least one of the meanings of a polysemous linguistic expression can be substituted in all its usages by a semantically equivalent linguistic expression, while the second meaning cannot be substituted by the same expression without semantic change.

By itself, this argument is flawed, as it potentially gives rise to an infinite number of so-called "polysemies". For example, using the same logic, one could argue that the English verb *to want* is polysemous between 'want very much' and 'want a little bit', as only the first meaning, but not the second one, can be substituted by the English verb *to long for*.

This last example suggests a different approach. When an English speaker uses the verb *to want*, (s)he does not need to specify whether 'want very much' or 'want a little bit' is meant, even though (s)he can, if necessary. Similarly, a Bahasa Indonesia speaker using *suka* might not need to specify whether 'want' or 'like/love' is meant, even though (s)he also can, if necessary.

These considerations evoke the notion of *macrofunctionality*, anticipated already in Comrie (1998) and Gil (2000), but distinctly formulated only in Gil (2004: 372): "Unlike polyfunctionality, which presupposes a plurality of functions, *macrofunctionality* assumes a single function, which may or may not be viably decomposable into a set of constituent subfunctions". In other words, some languages make distinctions that are insignificant for other languages, and in such cases there are generally no objective criteria to define which group of languages do this more 'naturally' and thus represent a more basic semantic pattern, and which do it less 'naturally' and thus represent a derived semantic pattern.[24] The simplest example might be that of color systems: e.g., English has one word *blue* whereas Russian has two words, *sinij* 'dark blue' and *goluboj* 'light blue'. The notion of macrofunctionality enables one to say that neither the English nor the Russian pattern is "basic", and that the English *blue* is macrofunctional, unifying in one function the ideas of 'dark blue' and 'light blue'. In fact, what is perceived as different functions by one language (e.g., 'light blue' and 'dark blue' by Russian, or a situation of wanting and a situation of liking by English) can readily be perceived as a single function by

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another language (e.g., 'blue' by English, or a situation of wanting/liking by Bahasa Indonesia). There is no way to tell whether the first language is splitting up one "originally" unitary semantic unit, or whether the second language is unifying two "originally" distinct units.[25] And in a situation of lack of evidence for either hypothesis it seems more objective not to accept the first one just because European languages thereby emerge as 'more natural', but to formulate a new and distinct hypothesis whereby the differences between the two former hypotheses are essentially neutralized. 'Macrofunctionality' looks like such a hypothesis — a weaker one, but one closer to the facts: it suggests that we think in terms of 'semantic vagueness' instead of 'semantic ambiguity' when approaching linguistic items of the type of English *blue* vis-à-vis items of the type of Russian *sinij* and *goluboj*.

This is the approach I propose to take here for desideratives. Some desideratives are macrofunctional, while others are not: the so-called 'multiple meanings' are thus reinterpreted as macrofunction. The results of my study make it reasonable to posit that the linguistic objects called desideratives are used to denote a SPECTRUM of physical and mental states. The spectral width can vary from quite narrow, comprising just wanting, to considerably broader, comprising other situations enumerated in Sections 3–4 as well. It is, though, crucial to claim that — until the opposite is proven — the spectrum is perceived as *indivisible* in each case: even speakers of languages where it is quite wide nonetheless perceive it as a unitary whole. An additional argument for the claim is the preference (mentioned in Section 5) that languages have for desideratives with only one meaning in addition to 'want'; arguably, more complex 'combinations of meanings' are more difficult to perceive as an indivisible whole.

Having chosen this type of reasoning, I find myself quite skeptical regarding the following reflection of Harkins (1995: 59) re Bahasa Indonesia *suka*:

> We may like coffee but not want any just now; or we may find that when we get something we want, we don't like it after all.

This idea of wanting vs. liking is based on the English lexicon, which makes a clear distinction between wanting and liking. I have serious doubts whether the relationship between the two situations is the same in a language having one word *suka* for both of them. Moreover, the result of language-culture interaction is evident here: it is difficult, if indeed possible, to determine whether speakers of Bahasa Indonesia have one word where English speakers have two words because of their culture, or whether their culture does not differentiate between the two situations because of their language. Similarly, the inventory of meanings/functions available to the desideratives of the world languages, as presented in this paper, has been based on the European cultural model and perforce contains only those situations that are conceivable for speakers of a Standard Average European language.

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Following the same logic, the label 'desideratives' is worth using only as a starting point of investigation or as a useful methodological heuristic, while it might not be a pertinent reality in the languages of the world. Actually, as many as 30 languages of the representative sample of 73 languages have only desideratives which denote a situation of wanting *and also* some other (non-wanting) situation — i.e. in these languages, expressing the situation of "wanting" (in European terms) is often impossible without simultaneously expressing some other situation.

Therefore, the status of WANT as a semantic prime/universal, as claimed in the Natural Semantic Metalanguage framework, is not evident. While its proponents do acknowledge the problem (Harkins 1995, Goddard & Wierzbicka 1994, Goddard & Wierzbicka 2002), they insist on the existence of syntactic or semantic conditions unambiguously governing the choice between WANT and the other meaning in almost every case of a desiderative having an alternative meaning.[26] But in Sections 3 and 4 of this paper it was shown that a fully conditioned distribution of meanings is really quite rare (only 27 meanings out of 162, i.e. 17%) and that a partially conditioned distribution is only about twice as frequent (44 meanings out of 162, i.e. 27%); a conditioned distribution of any kind is thus attested in only 44% of cases.[27]

However, the methodology of the polysemy issue is far from being very transparent in the NSM framework on itself, in a sense that an outsider cannot always prove or disprove its existence for a given lexeme, cf. "…there seem to be no rigorous external (= *external to the NSM theory assumptions, O.Kh.*) controls on the postulation of polysemy" (Riemer 2003: 291).[28] In Koptjevskaja-Tamm & Ahlgren (2003: 254–259) it was rather convincingly demonstrated that the NSM theory is indeed highly speculative re the distinction between polysemy and allolexy, and in passim, between vagueness and polysemy: "…determining whether we are dealing with allolexy or with polysemy can be far from obvious — and that differences and similarity may be (and often are) estimated relatively to the predetermined goal" (ibid: 258). Therefore I suspect that NSM theorists might find some arguments to disprove my statement based on the absence of any conditions governing the polysemy of desideratives in so many languages, using exactly the same data. It means, however, that it is not possible to determine the status of the phenomena (vagueness vs. polysemy) in the framework of the NSM theory, because, as stated above, this theory gives the 'predetermined goal' the power to decide it.

Does this mean that my reasoning in this section is pointless? Not necessarily, as I assume the readers might accept not only argumentation in lines with the NSM theory, but also beyond it. Thus, my claim that 'want' is not a semantic prime might not really hold, as this claim is (or is not) valid only within the theory of semantic primes, i.e. the NSM theory. However it can be reformulated in a way free from any references to the NSM: 'want' does not represent a semantic unit finding its *exclusive* expression in all languages of the world.

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Thus my survey of desideratives questions the WANT universal, not primarily on the basis of theoretical reasons, though these do exist, but rather by appeal to new evidence differing crucially from what was known about desideratives earlier. Reflecting on the sources of the difference, it could have emerged either from my having used a more principled sample,[29] or from the absence of any preconceived idea of the results. In planning and conceptualizing my study, I did not aim to prove or disprove the existence of a WANT universal, but just to examine what wanting looks like cross-linguistically.

My results suggest that there are languages where WANT is indeed an indivisible and indefinable salient concept of the culture; and there are languages where it is not salient, being treated only as particular type of a more general situation. To put it differently, THE SALIENCE OF WANTING IS NOT UNIVERSAL, BUT RATHER A PARAMETER OF CROSS-LINGUISTIC VARIATION.

The idea of the parametric nature of the lexicalization of the NSM semantic primes is not new. Earlier Bohnemeyer (2003: 219–220) suggested such an option for any possible prime: "…what if semantic primes are like phonological features, in that there is a universal superset of which different languages may select different coherent subsets?" In other words, the author suggests to get rid of the Strong Lexicalization Hypothesis and start a scientific program which "explores the conditions under which particular meanings are lexicalized across languages". See also a similar statement pronounced by an author of the NSM volume Goddard & Wierzbicka (1994): "I doubt that all languages 'have words for' the conceptual primitives. This in no way challenges the idea of conceptual primitives, since concepts do not have to have names to be real" (Hale 1994: 282). Thus, following these authors, who seem to be sympathetic with the idea of existence of semantic primitive units, but not with that of their universal lexicalization, the present paper has suggested some empirical data supporting non-universality of the 'want' lexicalization.

However there still persists the question of why some desideratives denote a wider spectrum of situations, while others denote a narrower, more European-like one — i.e. what conditions the value of the parameter of saliency of 'want' (or, lexicalization of 'want' in terms of the NSM)? There are two possible modes of explanation here: with reference either to language-internal or to language-external factors. In the former case, the structural properties of a given language determine the functional range of its desideratives; in the latter case, something beyond the language itself, e.g. some specific facts of the culture, determines the function of desideratives in the given language. While the first approach seems more traditional for linguistics, I would cast doubt on it: the languages having 'wider' desideratives are too numerous, they belong to too many geographical areas and — by the nature of the sample — to too many genealogical families to have any common structural properties which are absent from languages with 'narrow' desideratives.

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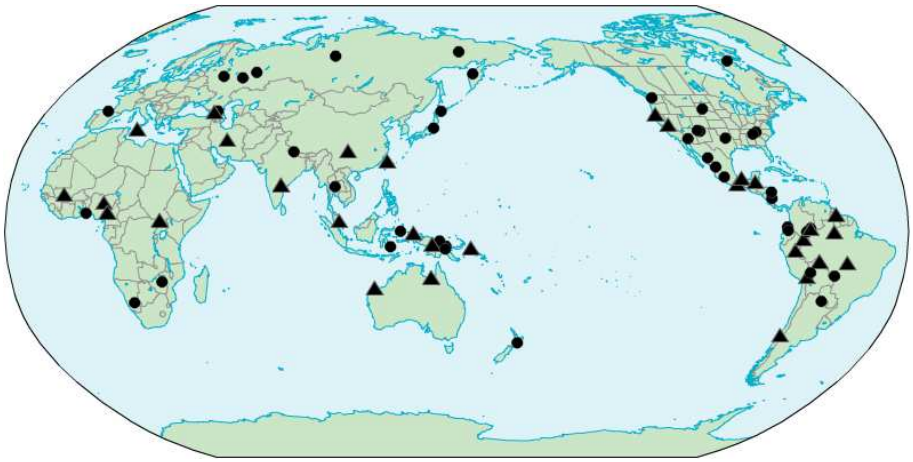


Figure 1. Sample languages[a]

[a] The figure was generated with the help of the Multimedia Reference Tool created by Hans-Jörg Bibiko (Max Plank Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology, Leipzig) for the World Atlas of Language Structures (WALS 2005); I would like to thank Hans-Jörg for his patience while introducing me to the program.

Figure 1 shows as triangles the 30 languages in which there are grammatical contexts where no desiderative can be used to unambiguously render wanting and nothing else at the same time.[30] The 43 languages with desideratives able to denote only wanting in all grammatical contexts are shown as circles.[31]

The presence of 'narrow' desideratives is typical for Eurasia without South Asia (cf. from west to east: Basque, Russian, Chuvash, Udmurt, Ket, Kolyma Yukaghir, Itelmen, Ainu, Japanese) and for North America (cf. Lushootseed, Maricopa, Navajo, Jemez, Lakota, Tepehua, Southeastern Tepehuan, Purepecha, Wichita, Labrador Inuttut, Koasati, Cherokee). It thus seems unrealistic to look for structural features common to these languages, but absent from other languages of the sample.

Therefore I choose the non-linguistic version, which proposes that the functional breadth of desideratives has no correlates in any other part of the language structure. It may well depend on some parameters of the culture of the given speech community, although my study, being purely linguistic, can neither point out these factors, nor state definitely their cultural nature. I do claim, however, that there is no *linguistic* factor determining the functional breadth of the desiderative(s) in a given language. In addition, the fact that rather similar numbers of languages (30 and 43) have each value of the 'narrow/wide' parameter would seem to speak for the total *independence* of the parameter: it appears to have equal chances of assuming either value in any human language, and thus to be stochastic by its very nature.

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As for the exact set of situations making up the semantic spectrum of 'want' expressions, reflection on its content may be too speculative before one has the results of the above-mentioned further diachronic study (Section 6, end). Indeed, without such a study there is a danger of falling into the pitfall of directly stating and explaining a semantic connection between wanting and some other situation, while in reality this connection may be only indirect, i.e. the situation in question may always go along with some other situation, the latter having the direct connection to wanting.

A very general argument may be made, however. Desideratives in the world's languages undoubtedly cover both semantic domains, the modal and the mental-emotive. This very fact refutes previous ideas of wanting either as an inherently modal situation or as a situation inherently belonging to the mental-emotive domain (for the first point of view, cf., among others, Bybee et al. (1994), Palmer (1986/2002), Plungian (2000), as well as many descriptive grammars; for the second point of view, cf. Givón (1980), Noonan (1985), as well as many descriptive grammars).

8. Conclusion

The main findings of the paper are:

1. Desideratives which are regularly used to express other situations as pure 'want' are much more frequent in the languages of my sample than desideratives which can be used only to express wanting (95 to 41).
2. From desideratives having additional meanings the most frequent are with only *one* additional meaning, followed by desideratives with several additional meanings belonging, though, to the *same* semantic group ('modal' or 'mental-emotive'); summing up, the simpler the 'addition' to the 'want' meaning is, the more chances it has to be attested by a desiderative.
3. Desideratives of all morphosyntactic types (verbs, nouns, affixes and particles), except constructions, show roughly the same proportion of desideratives having other meaning in addition to 'want'; yet each morphosyntactic type of desideratives favors only one semantic group as a source for the additional meanings: desiderative affixes and particles tend to have additional modal meanings, while desiderative verbs and nouns tend to have additional mental-emotive meanings.
4. Additional meanings of desideratives can be divided into core and peripheral: the core meanings are generally more frequent and are also attested by desideratives whose morphosyntactic type does not favor the given semantic

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type; the core modal meanings are 'near future/prospective', 'necessity', 'intention', 'obligation', 'illocution/causation', 'purpose', and 'ability', the core mental-emotive meanings are 'like/love', 'think', and 'say'.

5. Analysis of this cross-linguistic data has suggested that there is a significant variation in the spectrum of situations expressible by desideratives in the world languages, while the spectrum itself is claimed to be indivisible in individual languages. This claim is based on the fact that 30 from 73 sample languages have only such 'broad' desideratives which express more than a European situation of 'wanting', and for all these desideratives there were found no regular syntactic or semantic factors conditioning what was traditionally analyzed as 'polysemy'.
6. Thus, the idea of the universal salience of wanting, which is based on European linguistic and cultural evidence, was shown to be erroneous. Slightly less than half of the sample languages cannot — and do not need to — express the unambiguous concept of wanting, at least in some grammatical contexts; i.e. in these contexts wanting is just an interpretation of a broader or more complex concept.

More specifically, I have argued that 'want' is not a universal semantic prime in the sense of the Natural Semantic Metalanguage. There are too many languages all over the world that fail to express it through a *distinct* word, morpheme or fixed paraphrase, a necessary condition for a semantic prime Goddard (1994: 13). This very possibility of disproving a semantic prime is mentioned by Goddard (1998: 152): he says that a good counter-argument to any prime would be to show that in some language "there is apparently no term whatever which can be used to convey unambiguously the same idea as expressed" by the supposed prime.

To conclude I would like to cite the following statement of an NSM theorist

> This list (=*list of semantic primitives, O.Kh.*) was not seen to be final, and it was also clear that *the correctness of such a list could not be proved in a positive sense. It could only be demonstrated to be false*, in that it had to be tested by means of concrete semantic investigations (*emphasis is mine, O.Kh.*). (Durst 2003: 162)

I hope my semantic investigation has demonstrated convincingly enough that the inclusion of WANT in this list is indeed false.[32]

Notes

* The study reported in this paper was started during my stay at the Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology (Leipzig) in spring 2005. I would like to thank the Institute and particularly Bernard Comrie for inviting me and putting at my disposal the Institute's excellent

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resources and environment for typological research. The first version of the paper was presented at the MPI-EVA in May 2005; the acute comments of the audience helped me greatly in revising this paper, while the encouragement convinced me the paper was worth writing. I am especially grateful to Orin Gensler for crucial improvements to the style and language of the paper, as well as for many substantial comments. I would also like to thank Bernard Comrie, two anonymous reviewers, and Irina M. Kobozeva for their valuable comments to previous versions of this paper; I am also grateful to Edward Vajda who generously corrected some language mistakes. Last but not least, I am very much indebted to Alexander E. Kibrik for resolving my doubts about the value of studying desideratives. I acknowledge the support of the Fritz Thyssen Foundation during the revision of this paper.

1. Note, however, that some deviations from the Standard Average European idea of wanting can be found even within Europe, e.g. Spanish 'querer' is translated into English as both 'want' and 'love'.

2. The limitations of space do not let me to give the whole list of data sources for each language of the sample. This list is readily available on request from me, and can also be found at my web-site.

3. I would like to express my gratitude to Juliette Blevins (Yurok), Mark Donohue (Tukang Besi), Pattie Epps (Hup), Nick Evans (Kayardild), Tom Güldemann (Shona), Claire Lefebvre (Fongbe), Elena Maslova (Kolyma Yukaghir), Johanna Nichols and Sultan Mereshkov (Ingush), Masayuki Onishi (Japanese, Motuna), David Rood (Wichita), Andrey Shluinsky (Udmurt), Don Stilo (Colloquial Persian), Edward Vajda (Ket), Alejandra Vidal (Pilaga), Alexander Volodin (Itelmen), David Watters (Kham), Søren Wichmann (Texistepec Popoluca), and Alena Witzlack-Makarevitch (Nama).

4. The opposite point of view is quite common, cf. Goddard & Wierzbicka (1994, 2002) and Harkins (1995).

5. In the paper, the glossing mainly follows that of the original; minor changes were made for the sake of clarity and uniformity. The sole consistent difference vis-à-vis the original involves desideratives, which are always glossed as want/DESID regardless of their original glossing. The following abbreviations are used: 1 'first person', 2 'second person', 3 'third person', A 'agent-like argument of canonical transitive verb', ABL 'ablative', ACC 'accusative', ALL 'allative', ANAPH 'anaphora', APPL 'applicative', ART 'article', ATR 'attributive', CAUS 'causative', CEP 'counter-expectation particle', CL 'classifier', COMP 'complementizer', COND 'conditional', CONN 'connective', CONT 'continuous aspect', COP 'copula', DA 'dative-accusative', DAT 'dative', DEF 'definite', DEM 'demonstrative', DS 'different-subject', DU 'dual', EMPH 'emphatic', EQ 'predicative equative particle', ERG 'ergative', EVID 'direct evidential', EXIST 'existential predicator', EXT 'extension', F 'feminine', FAM 'familiar', FUT 'future', GEN 'genitive', HAB 'habitual', HORT 'hortative', IMP 'imperative', IMPFV 'imperfective', INCOMPL 'incompletive', INCH 'inchoative', INCL 'inclusive', IND 'indicative', INF 'infinitive', INTENS 'intensifier', INTER 'interrogative', INTR 'intransitive', IRR 'irrealis', LOC 'locative', M 'masculine', MM 'middle marking', NEG 'negation', NFIN 'non-final marker', NMLZ 'nominalizer', NOM 'nominative', NON 'not', NOW 'now', NPS 'nonpresent state', NRLD 'non-realized', O 'object', OBL 'oblique', OPT 'optative', PASS 'passive', PFV 'perfective', PL 'plural', POSS 'possessive', POT 'potential', PREP 'preposition', PROH 'prohibitive', PRS 'present tense', PST 'past tense', PURP 'purposive', REFL 'reflexive', REL 'relativizer', S 'subject', SG 'singular', SS 'same-subject', SSSS 'simultaneous event, same-subject,

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S-orientation', SUB 'subordinate', SUBJ 'subjunctive', SUPP 'support verb', TR 'transitive', TRL 'translative', TWD 'toward', U 'unmarked (any combination other than "human masculine")'.

6. In citing examples, I will underline the lexical item of the meta-language which conveys the desiderative (or relevant non-desiderative) semantics.

7. Etymologically, the particle *setake* is a desiderative verb *take* with personal 1SG prefix *se-*; as is clear from the example, the 1SG-form *setake* is now used as a desiderative for all persons and can thus be considered a particle.

8. In Maltese examples I have changed the author's transcription to standard orthography. I am grateful to Bernard Comrie who helped me with the shift between the orthographies and made some revisions in the glossing.

9. Meanings understood in this way will be given in single quotes, as is the standard practice for translational equivalents (e.g. French *vouloir* 'want').

10. For a detailed discussion of this type, see my doctoral thesis Khanina (2005) or Khanina (In prep).

11. The sum (59+52) exceeds 95, as there are desideratives having both modal and mental-emotive meanings, see Section 5 for details.

12. Whether a given concrete meaning is temporal ('near future') or aspectual ('prospective') in nature is not always easy to understand from existing descriptions, though the question is intrinsically quite important.

13. One may wonder why the meanings 'near future/prospective' and 'intention' were not unified in one meaning, while the illocutionary meanings 'imperative', 'optative', 'permission', and 'ask' were in fact unified in this way. Indeed, the conceptual distance between the 'near future/ prospective' and 'intention' meanings, on the one hand, and the distance between the 'imperative', 'optative', 'permission', and 'ask' meanings, on the other hand, seem not to be crucially different. However, both the 'near future/ prospective' meaning and the 'intention' meaning represent, each by itself, a salient meaning that is manifestly important for the study of wanting. The group of illocutionary meanings, by contrast, would not gain in saliency if treated individually: it is precisely the semantics of illocution per se that brings them interestingly close to the idea of wanting. In addition, grammatical descriptions generally tend to be quite vague about the difference between various illocutionary meanings, so that multiple 'distinct' illocutionary meanings may actually prove to be a single meaning (or two single meanings) upon closer analysis.

14. The Maori examples are from different sources; I have preserved the original orthographies.

15. Note, however, that this meaning is attested by the Kayardild suffix *-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru)* extremely rare (Nick Evans, p.c.).

16. The following desiderative is meant: the Shipibo-Konibo suffix *-kas.*

17. The following desideratives are meant: the Shipibo-Konibo verb *keen* and the Maori verb *piirangi.*

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18. No factors conditioning the choice were found in four cases: the Yagua affix *-rú́ú́y*, the Atayal verb *ŋluŋ*, the Bukiyip verb *-kli* and the Maybrat verb *-awe*.

19. The following desideratives are meant: the Navajo verb *zin* (which has the 'want' meaning when it follows the transitive conjugation, and the 'think' meaning when it follows the intransitive conjugation) and the Telugu verb *an* (which has the 'want' meaning when used with the reflexive marker *-ukon* and the 'think' meaning when used without it).

20. See Khanina (2005) or Khanina (In prep). for a detailed discussion of individual complementation strategies used by desiderative verbs to render the 'want', 'think' and 'say' meanings.

21. Regarding the cross-linguistic frequency, cf. the following citation from Haiman (1974: 341): "If a word exhibits polysemy in one language, one may be inclined, or forced, to dismiss its various meanings as coincidental; if a corresponding word in another language exhibits the same, or closely parallel polysemy, it becomes an extremely interesting coincidence; if it displays the same polysemy in four, five, or seven genetically unrelated languages, by statistical law it ceases to be a coincidence at all."

22. For the 'say' meaning only the general frequency criterion is applicable.

23. I would like to express my gratitude to Rie Hasada and Masayuki Onishi for their invaluable help with making this unpublished Australian dissertation available to me.

24. Discussing the fact that Riau Indonesian word *sama* may be translated into English as 'and', 'with', 'to', 'each other', 'also', 'same', etc., Gil (2004: 371) notes that "such an Anglocentric perspective tells us more about English than about the language under investigation, Riau Indonesian. Just because English *and*, *with*, *to*, and so forth have distinct functions does not mean that Riau Indonesian *sama* must necessarily be carved up isomorphically, into several distinct items, a $sama_1$ 'and', a $sama_2$ 'with', a $sama_3$ 'to' and so forth".

25. Note that these "originally" unitary semantic units are sometimes referred to in the NSM theory as 'lexical units': "The key analytical construct is 'lexical unit' — defined as the pairing of a *single specifiable sense* (meaning) with a lexical form… <…> A polysemous word is a lexeme which consists of more than one lexical unit (*emphasis is mine, O.Kh.*)" (Goddard 2001: 1–2).

26. At the end of her thesis, Jean Harkins says, "The studies of desiderative expressions offered above illustrate that, while it is unrealistic to seek unique form-meaning correspondences, meaning differences are usually, perhaps always, accompanied by some identifiable differences in linguistic form" (Harkins 1995: 235). Cf. also "… 'want' is a universally lexicalized meaning, though the situation is frequently complicated by language-specific patterns of polysemy which mean that the lexemes in question do not have identical ranges of use" (Goddard 2001: 30). Similarly, at the conclusion of her co-edited volume Goddard & Wierzbicka (1994), Anna Wierzbicka says, "Although the overwhelming conclusion emerging from the survey of languages is that there is indeed a universal 'alphabet of human thoughts' (Leibniz 1903(MS): 435), this by no means implies that no problems have arisen in testing our hypothetical set of conceptual and lexical universals… In particular, as the research reported here illustrates, polysemy (in a broad sense, covering also homonymy) is a major problem… One type of evidence which we regard as particularly telling is syntactic evidence. If 'the same word' can mean either SAY or WANT but each of these senses has a distinct syntactic frame… then we can regard this word as polysemous, and both meanings as having their own lexical exponent" (Wierzbicka 1994: 445).

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27. While absence of information may ultimately turn out to conceal a partially/fully conditioned distribution, the sheer quantity of cases involving "absence of information" is too large to make it likely that this will make a significant difference overall. If a clearly conditioned distribution of meanings were truly common, then information about it would surely find its place in grammatical descriptions in a more significant number of cases.

28. I would like to express my gratitude to Martin Haspelmath for making this issue of Theoretical Linguistics available to me.

29. Harkins (1995), despite being a typological enterprise, is based on a small convenience sample of 11 languages from 5 families that are studied in detail, and an arbitrary set of 84 languages from 32 families that are mentioned in passing in the text. As for Goddard & Wierzbicka (1994), Goddard & Wierzbicka (2002), these works are collections of papers describing semantic universals, but only in a haphazard selection of languages.

30. Here is the list of these languages: Atayal, Aymara, Babungo, Bambara, Berbice Dutch Creole, Chatino, Colloquial Persian, Georgian, Hixkaryana, Hmong (Njua), Hup, Itzaj Maya, Kamaiura, Kayardild, Korowai, Ma'di, Maltese, Mapuche, Martuthunira, Maybrat, Motuna, Mupun, Semelai, Shipibo-Konibo, Southern Sierra Miwok, Telugu, Texistepec Popoluca, Wari', Yagua, Yurok.

31. Here is the list of these languages: Ainu, Amele, Awa Pit, Barasano, Basque, Bororo, Bukiyip, Cherokee, Chuvash, Fongbe, Hua, Imbabura Quechua, Ingush, Itelmen, Japanese, Jemez, Ket, Kham, Koasati, Kolyma Yukaghir, Labrador Inuttut, Lakota, Lushootseed, Maori, Maricopa, Miskitu, Moseten, Nama, Navajo, Pilaga, Purepecha, Rama, Russian, Shona, Southeastern Tepehuan, Taba, Tariana, Tepehua, Thai, Tukang Besi, Udmurt, Wichita, Yimas.

32. Some readers might be surprised not to find a precise semantic definition of 'want' in the paper. While giving such a definition seems to be a plausible scientific enterprise on its own (and see some promising ideas in Harkins (1995: 203–207)), the methodology of the cross-linguistic study reported here did not suggest it. Indeed, only the translational equivalents were analyzed, but not the semantics of concept/situation that they refer to (the latter being rather difficult to capture for 73 languages to most of which I lack direct access). The results presented in this paper seem, though, to be valid even without such an analysis: epistemologically, the issue of universality of the concept 'X' is independent of the issue of the concrete internal structure of this concept.

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Appendix 1. Languages of the sample

Language	Genetic affiliation[a]
Ainu	Language Isolate
Amele	Trans New Guinea, Madang
Atayal	Austronesian, Formosan
Awa Pit (=Awa-Cuaiquer)	Barbacoan
Aymara	Aymaran
Babungo (=Vengo)	Niger-Congo, Benue-Congo, Bantoid
Bambara (=Bamanankan)	Niger-Congo, Mande, Western Mande
Barasano (=Barasana)	Tucanoan
Basque	Basque
Berbice Dutch Creole	Creole
Bororo	Macro-Ge
Bukiyip	Torricelli, Kombio-Arapesh
Chatino (Yaitepec)	Oto-Manguean, Zapotecan
Cherokee	Iroquoian, Southern Iroquoian
Chuvash	Altaic, Turkic
Persian Colloquial (=Western Farsi)	Indo-European, Indo-Iranian
Fongbe (=Fon)	Niger-Congo, Kwa
Georgian	Kartvelian (=South Caucasian)
Hixkaryana	Carib
Hmong (Njua)	Hmong-Mien
Hua (=Huva, Yagaria)	Trans-New Guinea, Eastern Highlands
Hup (=Hupde)	Vaupes-Japura (=Maku)
Imbabura Quechua (=Quichua, Imbabura Highland)	Quechuan
Ingush	Nakh-Daghestanian (=East Caucasian), Nakh
Itelmen	Chukotko-Kamchatkan
Itzaj Maya	Mayan
Japanese	Japanese

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Language	Genetic affiliation[a]
Jemez	Kiowa-Tanoan
Kamaiura (=Kamayura)	Tupi, Tupi-Guarani
Kayardild	(Australian) Tangic
Ket	Yeniseian
Kham	Sino-Tibetan, Tibeto-Burman
Koasati	Muskogean
Kolyma Yukaghir	Yukaghir
Korowai	Trans-New Guinea, Awyu-Dumut
Labrador Intuttut	Eskimo-Aleut
Lakota (=Lakhota)	Siouan
Lushootseed (=Puget Sound Coast Salish)	Salish, Central Salish
Ma'di	Nilo-Saharan, Central Sudanic, Moru-Ma'di
Maltese	Afro-Asiatic, Semitic
Maori	Austronesian, Eastern Malayo-Polynesian
Mapuche (=Mapudungun)	Araucanian
Maricopa	(Hokan) Yuman
Martuthunira	(Australian) Pama-Nyungan
Maybrat (=Mai Brat)	West Papuan, North-Central Bird's Head
Miskitu (=Miskito)	Misumalpan
Moseten	Mosetenan
Motuna	(East Papuan) East Bougainville
Mupun	Afro-Asiatic, Chadic, West-Chadic
Nama (=Hottentot/ KhoeKhoe)	(Khoisan) Central Khoisan
Navajo	Na-Dene, Athapaskan
Pilaga	Guaicuruan
Purepecha	Tarascan
Rama	Chibchan
Russian	Indo-European, Slavic
Semelai	Austro-Asiatic, Mon-Khmer
Shipibo-Konibo (=Shipibo-Conibo)	Panoan
Shona	Niger-Congo, Benue-Congo, Bantoid
Southeastern Tepehuan	Uto-Aztecan, Tepiman
Southern Sierra Miwok	(Penutian) Utian, Miwok
Taba (=East Makian/ Makian Dalam)	Austronesian, Eastern Malayo-Polynesian
Tariana	Arawakan
Telugu	Dravidian, South-Central Dravidian
Tepehua (Tlachichilco)	Totonacan
Texistepec Popoluca	Mixe-Zoque
Thai	Tai-Kadai, Kam-Tai
Tukang Besi	Austronesian, Western Malayo-Polynesian

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Language	Genetic affiliation[a]
Udmurt	Uralic, Finno-Ugric
Wari' (=Pacaasnovos)	Chapacura-Wanham
Wichita	Caddoan
Yagua	Peba-Yaguan
Yimas	Lower Sepik-Ramu, Nor-pondo (=Lower Sepik)
Yurok	Algic, Yurok

[a] Language names and genetic affiliation are given form Gordon (2005) and WALS (2005). The level of details follows the model provided by WALS (2005); the full genealogical affiliation can be found in the web-version of Gordon (2005) at www.ethnologue.com.

Appendix 2. Desideratives having 'near future/prospective' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Awa Pit	*-shi(ta)-*	affix
Barasano	*-rʉ(a)-*	affix
Hua	*-su-/-si-/-sa-*	affix
Itelmen	*-aɬ-/-a-*	affix
Kayardild	*-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru)*	affix
Kham	*-rih-*	affix
Labrador Inuttut	*-guma-*	affix
Southeastern Tepehuan	*-m*	affix
Southern Sierra Miwok	*-jnY-*	affix
Tepehua	*-putun-*	affix
Texistepec Popoluca	*-to'*	affix
Texistepec Popoluca	*-tä'*	affix
Yagua	*-rú́ú́y*	affix
Colloquial Persian	*xāstan*	verb
Hmong	*yuav/yŭa*	verb
Hua	*-hu-/-hi-/-ha-*	verb
Hup	*-tú(k)-*	verb
Kham	*pəĩ*	verb
Rama	*bating*	verb
Shona	*-da/-dá:*	verb
Tukang Besi	*hada*	verb
Semelai	*lən*	particle
Itzaj Maya	*tak*	particle
Wari'	–	construction

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Appendix 3. Desideratives having 'necessity' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Moseten	*-wei-*	affix
Berbice Dutch Creole	*suk(u)*	verb
Colloquial Persian	*xāstan*	verb
Hmong	*yuav/yŭa*	verb
Ingush	*-ieza*	verb
Itzaj Maya	*k'a't*	verb
Koasati	*bànnan*	verb
Kolyma Yukaghir	*erd'e:*	verb
Lushootseed	*xa'ƛ'*	verb
Ma'di	*lɛ̀*	verb
Motuna	*haa*	verb
Purepecha	*'ueka/'weka*	verb
Southeastern Tepehuan	*-'a'*	verb
Southern Sierra Miwok	*hejaHw-ŋhe*	verb
Thai	*tɔ̂ŋkaan*	verb
Lushootseed	*sxa'ƛ'*	noun
Semelai	*lən*	particle

Appendix 4. Desideratives having 'intention' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Barasano	*-rʉ(a)-*	affix
Chuvash	*-sšăn/-sšĕn*	affix
Shipibo-Konibo	*-kas*	affix
Babungo	*kə́ə*	verb
Chuvash	*šutla/šuxăšla*	verb
Chuvash	*te*	verb
Hua	*-hu-/-hi-/-ha-*	verb
Korowai	*tekhénmo*	verb
Maricopa	*'i(i)-*	verb
Maybrat	*-awe*	verb
Rama	*bating*	verb
Russian	*xotet'*	verb
Semelai	*mɔh*	verb
Texistepec Popoluca	*sun*	verb
Tukang Besi	*hada*	verb

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Appendix 5. Desideratives having 'obligation' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Hua	*-su-/-si-/-sa-*	affix
Kayardild	*-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru)*	affix
Korowai	special (so-called "intentional/ adhortative/ imperative") set of cross-reference affixes	affix
Southern Sierra Miwok	*-jnY-*	affix
Georgian	*-nd-*	verb
Ingush	*-ieza*	verb
Maltese	*ried*	verb
Maricopa	*'i(i)-*	verb
Telugu	-	construction

Appendix 6. Desideratives having 'illocution/causation' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type	Concrete meaning (if applicable)
Labrador Inuttut	*-tqu-*	affix	'ask/order'
Southeastern Tepehuan	*-'a'*	verb	'ask'
Hmong	*xav/xaav/sǎŋ*	verb	'order'
Korowai	special (so-called "intentional/ adhortative/ imperative") set of cross-reference affixes	affix	'imperative/optative'
Hua	*-su-/-si-/-sa-*	affix	'imperative/optative'
Ma'di	*lɛ̀*	verb	'permit'

Appendix 7. Desideratives having 'purpose' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Tukang Besi	*-um-*	affix
Southeastern Tepehuan	*-m*	affix
Korowai	special (so-called "intentional/ adhortative/ imperative") set of cross-reference affixes	affix
Kayardild	*-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru)*	affix
Labrador Inuttut	*-tqu-*	affix
Atayal	*aki'/aki*	particle
Maori	*tuumanako*	noun

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Appendix 8. Desideratives having 'ability' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Kayardild	*-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru)*	affix
Kamaiura	*-potat-*	affix
Yagua	*-rų́ų́y*	affix
Semelai	*mɔh*	verb
Semelai	*lən*	particle

Appendix 9. Desideratives having occasional modal meanings

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type	Individual meaning
Yagua	*-rų́ų́y*	affix	'attempt'
Ket	*-tabaq*	verb	'attempt'
Maricopa	*'i(i)-*	verb	'attempt'
Korowai	special (so-called "intentional/ adhortative/ imperative") set of cross-reference affixes	affix	'unreal'
Tukang Besi	*-um-*	affix	'unreal'
Atayal	*aki'/aki*	particle	'unreal'
Southern Sierra Miwok	*-jnY*	affix	'readiness'
Kayardild	*-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru)*	affix	'repetition in the past'

Appendix 10. Desideratives having 'like/love' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Shipibo-Konibo	*-kas*	affix
Aymara	*mun(a)*	verb
Bororo	*aidɨ/aidu*	verb
Chatino	*katiʔ*	verb
Ingush	*-eza*	verb
Itzaj Maya	*kä't*	verb
Itzaj Maya	*k'äm*	verb
Kamaiura	*potat/potar*	verb
Lushootseed	*xaƛ'*	verb
Ma'di	*lɛ̀*	verb

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Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Maori	*piirangi*	verb
Mapuche	*ayü*	verb
Martuthunira	*wirunpa*	verb
Mupun	*ɗem/dem*	verb
Mupun	*ɗien/ɗyèn/ɗien*	verb
Mupun	*wàl*	verb
Purepecha	*ʻueka/ʼweka*	verb
Shipibo-Konibo	*keen*	verb
Shona	*-ɗa/-ɗá:*	verb
Southern Sierra Miwok	*hejaHw-ŋhe*	verb
Tukang Besi	*hada*	verb
Yagua	*-vạạta*	verb
Yurok	*skewok(sim)*	verb
Amele	*gale*	noun
Ingush	*bezam*	noun
Lushootseed	*sxaʼḷ*	noun
Martuthunira	*wiru*	noun
Taba	*suka*	noun
Awa Pit	–	construction
Bambara	–	construction
Hixkaryana	*xe*	particle
Mapuche	*küpá*	particle

Appendix 11. Desideratives having ‘think’ meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Yagua	*-rúúy*	affix
Atayal	*ŋluŋ*	verb
Bukiyip	*-kli*	verb
Chuvash	*šutla/šuxăšla*	verb
Hmong	*xav/xaav/săŋ*	verb
Kham	*(həi) li*	verb
Maricopa	*alyʼi(i)-*	verb
Maybrat	*-awe*	verb
Navajo	*zin*	verb
Telugu	*an-*	verb
Wariʼ	–	construction

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Appendix 12. Desideratives having 'say' meaning

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type
Bukiyip	*-kli*	verb
Chuvash	*te*	verb
Hua	*-hu-/-hi-/-ha-*	verb
Kayardild	*kamburi*	verb
Kham	*(hɔi) li*	verb
Mapuche	*pi-*	verb
Maricopa	*'i(i)-*	verb
Maybrat	*-awe*	verb
Telugu	*an-*	verb
Tepehua	*nahun*	verb

Appendix 13. Desideratives having occasional mental-emotive meanings

Language	Desiderative	Morphosyntactic type	Concrete meaning
Atayal	*ŋluŋ*	verb	'feel'
Martuthunira	*wirunpa*	verb	'feel'
Telugu	*an*	verb	'feel'
Yimas	*ty*	verb	'feel'
Martuthunira	*wiru*	noun	'feel'
Ingush	*low*	verb	'accept/agree'
Itzaj Maya	*k'äm*	verb	'accept/agree'
Motuna	*haa*	verb	'accept/agree'
Mupun	*ɗem/dem*	verb	'accept/agree'
Hmong	*xav/xaav/ săŋ*	verb	'hope'
Kham	*(hɔi) li*	verb	'hope'
Maori	*tuumanako*	noun	'hope'
Bukiyip	*kli*	verb	'know'
Navajo	*zin*	verb	'know'
Chuvash	*te*	verb	'decide'
Maybrat	*awe*	verb	'decide'
Miskitu	*plikaia*	verb	'look for'
Udmurt	-	construction	'seem'

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Appendix 14. Desiderative verbs having modal meanings

Language	Core modal meaning	Desiderative verb
Hua	'near future'	*-hu-/-hi-/-ha-*
Hup		*-tú(k)-*
Kham		*pəĩ*
Rama		*bating*
Shona		*-ɗa/-dá*
Tukang Besi		*hada*
Hmong		*yuav/yŭa*
Colloquial Persian		*xāstan*
Lushootseed	'necessity'	*xaʾƛʾ*
Motuna		*haa-*
Koasati		*bànnan*
Hmong		*yuav/yŭa*
Itzaj Maya		*kʾaʾt*
Kolyma Yukaghir		*erďe:*
Thai		*tɔ̂ŋkaan*
Ingush		*-ieza*
Maʾdi		*lɛ̀*
Colloquial Persian		*xāstan*
Southern Sierra Miwok		*hejaHw-ŋhe*
Southeastern Tepehuan		*-ʾa*
Purepecha		*ʻueka/ʾweka*
Berbice Dutch Creole		*suk(u)*
Babungo	'intention'	*kə́ə*
Hua		*hu-/-hi-/-ha-*
Korowai		*tekhénmo*
Maricopa		*ʻi(i)-*
Maybrat		*-awe*
Rama		*bating*
Semelai		*mɔh*
Tukang Besi		*hada*
Chuvash		*šutla/šuxăšla*
Chuvash		*te*
Russian		*xotetʾ*
Texistepec Popoluca		*sun-*
Georgian	'obligation'	*-nd-*
Ingush		*-ieza*
Maltese		*ried*
Maricopa		*ʻi(i)-*

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Language	Core modal meaning	Desiderative verb
Hmong	'illocution/causation'	*xav/xaav/sǎŋ*
Ma'adi		*lɛ̀*
Southeastern Tepehuan		*-'a'*
Semelai	'ability'	*mɔh*
Ket	'attempt'	*tabaq*
Maricopa		*'i(i)-*

Appendix 15. Desiderative affixes and particles having mental-emotive meanings

Language	Core mental-emotive meaning	Desiderative affix/particle
Mapuche	'like/love'	*küpá*
Hixkaryana		*xe*
Shipibo-Konibo		*-kas*
Yagua	'think'	*-rú́ú́y*

Appendix 16. Desiderative nouns having modal meanings

Language	Core modal meaning	Desiderative noun
Lushootseed	'necessity'	*sxa'ʌ'*
Maori	'purpose'	*tuumanako*

Appendix 17. Desiderative constructions having other meanings in addition to 'want'

Language	Core modal/mental-emotive meaning
Bambara	'like/love'
Awa Pit	
Wari'	'think', 'near future'
Udmurt	'seem'
Telugu	'obligation'

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Appendix 18. Desideratives having peripheral meanings

Peripheral meaning	Number of desideratives having it	Number of desideratives having it together with some core meaning		Number of desideratives having it without any core meaning	
'attempt'	3	2	*'i(i)-* (Maricopa): 'intention', 'obligation', 'say' *-rúúy* (Yagua): 'ability', 'near future', 'think'	1	*tabaq* (Ket)
'unreal'	3	3	*-um-* (Tukang Besi): 'purpose' special (so called "intentional/ adhortative/ imperative") set of cross-reference affixes (Korowai): 'obligation', 'illocution/causation', 'purpose' *aki'/aki* (Atayal): 'purpose'	0	
'readiness'	1	1	*-jnY-* (Southern Sierra Miwok): 'near future', 'obligation'	0	
'repetition in the past'	1	1	*-Thu(ru)/-nangku(ru)* (Kayardild): 'near future', 'obligation', 'ability', 'purpose'	0	
'feel'	5	4	*ŋluŋ* (Atayal): 'think' *an-* (Telugu): 'say', 'think' *wirunpa-* (Martuthunira): 'like/ love' *wiru-* (Martuthunira): 'like/love'	1	*-ty-* (Yimas)
'accept/ agree'	4	3	*k'äm* (Itzaj Maya): 'like/love' *ɗem/dem* (Mupun): 'like/love' *haa-* (Motuna): 'necessity'	1	*low* (Ingush)
'know'	2	2	*-zin* (Navajo): 'think' *-kli* (Bukiyip): 'say', 'think'	0	
'hope'	3	3	*xav/xaav/ săŋ* (Hmong): 'illocution/causation', 'think' *(həi) li* (Kham): 'say', 'think' *Tuumanako* (Maori): 'purpose'	0	
'decide'	2	2	*te-* (Chuvash): 'say', 'intention' *-awe* (Maybrat): 'intention', 'say', 'think'	0	
'look for'	1	0		1	*plikaia* (Miskitu)
'seem'	1	0		1	construction (Udmurt)
total	26 (100%)	21 (81%)		5 (19%)	

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